

Glossary

Abdomen The lower part of the main body (the torso), below your chest.

Absorption The process by which nutrients from digested food are taken in through the wall of your small intestine and passed into your blood.

Adrenaline A hormone that prepares your body for sudden action in times of danger or excitement. Adrenaline is produced by glands on top of the kidneys.

Allergy An illness caused by overreaction of the body's immune system to a normally harmless substance.

Amino acid A simple molecule used by the body to build proteins. Proteins in food are broken down into amino acids by the digestive system.

Antibody A substance made by the body that sticks to germs and marks them for destruction by white blood cells.

Antigen A foreign substance, usually found on the surface of pathogens such as bacteria, which triggers the immune system to respond.

Artery A blood vessel that carries blood away from your heart to your body's tissues and organs.

Autonomic nervous system (ANS) The part of the nervous system that controls unconscious functions such as your heart rate and the size of the pupil in your eyes.

Axon A long fiber that extends from a nerve cell (neuron). It carries electrical signals away from the cell.

Bacterium (plural **Bacteria**) A small type of microorganism. Bacteria live everywhere. Some types cause disease in humans, but some are beneficial and help keep your body functioning properly.

Blood A liquid tissue containing several types of cells. Blood carries oxygen, salts, nutrients, minerals, and hormones around your body. It also collects waste for disposal, such as carbon dioxide that is breathed out by your lungs.

Blood vessel Any tube that carries blood through your body.

Bone A strong, hard body part made chiefly of calcium minerals. There are 206 bones in an adult skeleton.

Brain stem The part of the base of your brain that connects to your spinal cord.

Calcium A mineral used by your body to build bones and teeth. Calcium also helps muscles move.

Capillary The smallest type of blood vessel. Your body contains thousands of miles of capillaries.

Carbohydrate A food group that includes sugars and starches that provide your body's main energy supply.

Cartilage A tough, flexible type of connective tissue that helps support your body and covers the ends of bones in joints.

Cell The smallest living unit of your body.

Central nervous system Your brain and spinal cord together make up your central nervous system. One of the two main parts of the nervous system.

Cerebellum A small, cauliflower-shaped structure at the base of the back of your brain that helps coordinate body movements and balance.

Cerebral cortex The deeply folded, outer layer of your brain. It is used for thinking, memory, movement, language, attention, and processing sensory information.

Cerebral hemisphere One of the two symmetrical halves into which the main part of your brain (the cerebrum) is split.

Cerebrum The largest part of the brain, which is involved in conscious thought, feelings, and movement.

► **SPIRAL SHAPE**
DNA has a double-helix structure that looks like a twisted ladder.

